

Winning Ambition Training Script

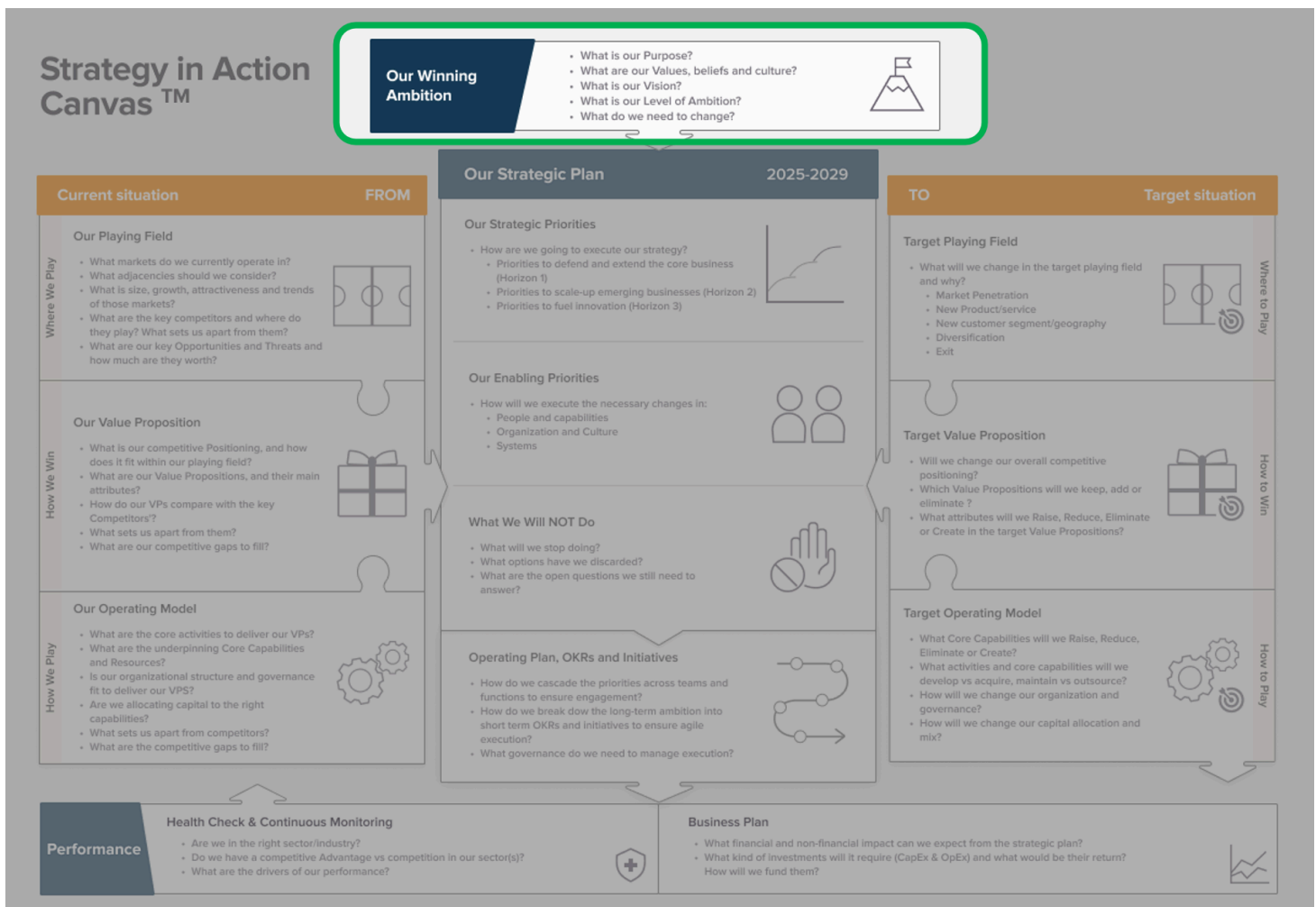
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Section 1: Winning Ambition - What It Is and Why It Is Important

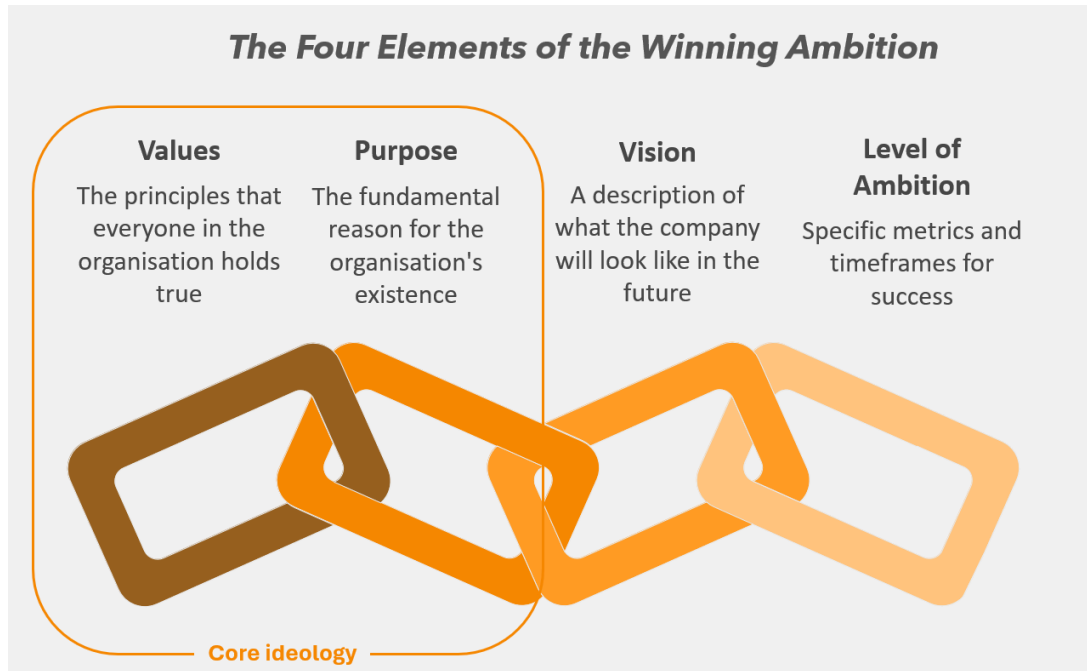
Welcome to our exploration of Winning Ambition - the very first element of the Strategy in Action Canvas. We'll dive deep into what makes organisations truly successful by understanding how they define and articulate their purpose, values, vision, and level of ambition.

The Winning Ambition represents the precursor to all strategic choices. It's the North Star that guides every decision an organisation makes. Think of it as the strategy's DNA - it defines why the company exists, what success looks like, and what kind of future the organisation is trying to create. It must be aspirational and stretching, requiring the organisation to reach beyond its current capabilities and comfort zone to achieve something genuinely ambitious.

The Winning Ambition is not just another corporate mission statement that sits on a wall gathering dust. It's a living, breathing framework that directly addresses the "Strategy Chasm" - that dangerous gap between what organisations aspire to achieve and what they actually have the capability to deliver.

When organisations suffer from this chasm, sometimes it's because they've never clearly defined what winning means for them. They have vague aspirations like "be the best" or "maximise shareholder value" without connecting these goals to concrete, actionable outcomes that their people can rally around and their capabilities can actually deliver.

The Four Elements of Winning Ambition



The Winning Ambition framework we're exploring today consists of four interconnected elements, and I want you to notice how each one builds on the others to create a coherent foundation for strategic action. Each of these elements is important and necessary, as it is important that each element is correctly framed. It is ever so common to find Corporate presentation which illustrate these elements, but it is truly rare to find them correctly framed.

Let's start with some basic definitions:

Values are the essential behavioural values and principles which everyone in the organisation holds true and which distinguish and characterise the unique culture of the organisation.

Purpose is the "raison d'être" - the reason to exist of the organisation, the ultimate synthesis of the organisational culture. It is tempting to believe that companies exist to make money, but it would be a big mistake. Profit is necessary for a company to exist, but it never represents the true purpose. Think about it as oxygen for people: necessary for survival but hardly representing anyone's true purpose in life.

Vision is the description of what the company will look like in the future. It provides a vivid image of a future that doesn't exist yet. What will we have achieved? What will the customer think of us? And our

colleagues? What will we be known for? It is very common to find vision statements which are in reality descriptions of purpose, as "envisioning the future" is a difficult task for which too often leadership doesn't find time for.

Level of Ambition refers to building a set of measurable metrics with a current (from) and a target (to) value, which are the numerical representation of the Vision, Purpose and Values. In other words, they act as GPS coordinates for the other elements of the winning ambition. This element complements the "narrative" nature of the previous elements, which are defined using words and vivid images, with hard and measurable metrics. Words are important as they engage people at an emotional level, but they are interpretable. With the level of ambition, the leadership team and the rest of the organisation must converge in a common, non-interpretable definition of what these words mean, in numbers. What numbers will tell us unequivocally that we have reached our winning ambition.

Let's now explore more in details each of these elements.

Values and Purpose: the core ideology of the Company

Values and Purpose together form what we call the "core ideology" of the organisation - the fundamental beliefs and reasons for existence that remain constant over time. Core ideology represents the organisation's authentic identity. It's what the organisation stands for at its deepest level, independent of market conditions, competitive pressures, or leadership changes.

Because Values and Purpose represent this core ideology - the authentic essence of who the organisation truly is - there's a critical distinction that most organisations get wrong: You do not CREATE or SET your purpose and values. You DISCOVER them. You don't deduce them by looking at the external environment - you understand them by looking inside. Core purposes and values must be authentic. You cannot fake them.

This means asking not "What core values should we hold?" but "What core values do we truly and passionately hold?" Don't confuse values that you think the organisation ought to have with authentic core values. To do so creates cynicism throughout the organisation. As Collins and Porras found in their research, the authenticity, discipline, and consistency with which ideology is lived - not the content of the ideology - differentiates purpose-driven companies from the rest.

The performance advantages of purpose-driven organisations are now well-documented across multiple academic and industry studies. Research shows that purpose-driven companies are three times more likely to retain talent due to higher levels of employee engagement and job satisfaction, with firms reporting a 30% increase in innovation rates. These organisations experience an annual return on equity averaging 13.1%, which is 9% higher than the S&P, and retain employees who are 64% more satisfied with their work (Gleeson, 2024, Forbes).

Harvard Business School research demonstrates that companies exhibiting both high purpose and clarity from management have systematically higher future financial and stock market performance. Importantly, this relationship is driven by the perceptions of middle management and professional staff rather than senior executives, suggesting that the clarity of purpose must permeate throughout the organisation to be effective (Gartenberg, Prat, & Serafeim, 2019, Organisation Science).

Academic research confirms that corporate purpose serves as a direct antecedent to both employee motivation and work engagement. The study found that purpose positively associates with autonomous motivation (where employees find intrinsic value in their work) and negatively with motivation (where work feels meaningless). Companies with employees who maintain strong beliefs in the meaning of their work consistently experience better performance across multiple dimensions (van Tuin, Schaufeli, Van den Broeck, & van Rhenen, 2020, Frontiers in Psychology).

Research reveals that while 79% of business leaders believe purpose is central to success, only 34% say their company has clearly articulated its purpose. This gap represents a significant opportunity, as companies with purpose-driven cultures have employees who are 1.4 times more engaged and productive, and organisations with a strong sense of purpose are five times more likely to deliver breakthrough innovations (Durand & Ioannou, 2023, Harvard Business Review).

If you previously believed that values and purpose are merely "soft" elements that don't concern the executive leadership of the organisation, hopefully this research evidence may encourage you to reconsider. The data clearly demonstrates that purpose-driven organisations deliver superior financial performance, higher innovation rates, and better talent retention - making purpose a critical strategic imperative, not an optional nice-to-have.

Purpose

The first element is your Core Purpose - the organisation's most fundamental reason for being beyond making money. This goes far beyond typical mission statements. Your core purpose should reflect people's idealistic motivations for doing the company's work and should last at least 100 years. It doesn't describe your current products or target customers; it captures the soul of the organisation.

Examples of Core Purpose

	Company	Purpose
01		<i>To organise the world's information and make it universally accessible and useful.</i>
02		<i>To empower every person and every organization on the planet to achieve more.</i>
03		<i>To help our clients make distinctive, lasting, and substantial improvements in their performance and to build a great firm that is able to attract, develop, excite, and retain exceptional people.</i>
04		<i>To experience the emotion of competition, winning, and crushing competitors.</i>
05		<i>To make technical contributions for the advancement and welfare of humanity.</i>

An effective core purpose should inspire people at all levels of the organisation and provide guidance about what core to preserve as everything else changes around you. As David Packard said to HP employees in 1960: "I want to discuss why a company exists in the first place... we inevitably come to the conclusion that a group of people get together and exist as an institution that we call a company so they are able to accomplish something collectively that they could not accomplish separately - they make a contribution to society."

Take Google, for example. Their purpose was never to build search engines but "to organise the world's information and make it universally accessible and useful." This purpose has guided them consistently from their very first simple white webpage with just a search field to the galaxy of products and technologies they offer today. Every major expansion can be traced back to this core purpose: Gmail tackled email communication, Google Maps addressed geographic navigation, YouTube centralised video content, Google Scholar catalogued academic research, and Google Books digitised literary works. When they moved into cloud computing with Google Cloud, they managed enterprise data infrastructure. Their development of Android unified mobile information. Even their ambitious moonshot projects through Alphabet - from self-driving cars that process transportation data to DeepMind advancing artificial intelligence research - all serve their fundamental purpose across new domains and frontiers.

Microsoft exists not to make software but "to empower every person and every organisation on the planet to achieve more." From their early MS-DOS and Windows operating systems that democratised personal computing, to today's comprehensive ecosystem, every strategic move reflects this empowerment mission. Office revolutionised workplace productivity, Windows Server enhanced enterprise capabilities, and Xbox expanded entertainment possibilities. Their pivot to cloud computing with Azure empowered businesses to scale globally, while acquisitions like LinkedIn strengthened

professional networking and GitHub supported developer communities. Surface devices enabled mobile productivity, Teams facilitated remote collaboration, and HoloLens opened mixed reality frontiers. Even their recent AI initiatives like Copilot aim to augment human capabilities across every domain - all manifestations of their unwavering commitment to helping people and organisations achieve more than they thought possible.

Nike's purpose isn't to make athletic shoes but "to experience the emotion of competition, winning, and crushing competitors." From their early running shoes designed to help athletes break records, to today's global empire of performance and lifestyle, every strategic decision channels this competitive spirit. Their "Just Do It" campaign captured the mindset of overcoming obstacles, while sponsoring legends like Michael Jordan, Serena Williams, and Cristiano Ronaldo embodied athletic dominance. Nike Air technology pushed performance boundaries, while their entry into basketball, soccer, and countless other sports expanded their competitive arena. Digital innovations like Nike+ and the Nike Training Club app brought competition to personal fitness, while Nike Pro gear equipped athletes for elite performance. Their sustainability initiatives through Move to Zero even frame environmental responsibility as winning against climate change. Whether it's limited-edition drops that create competitive scarcity or partnerships with elite teams that chase championships, Nike consistently transforms the pursuit of victory into cultural movements that inspire millions to compete, perform, and win.

When discovering, re-defining and communicating your purpose, you will face several options, each leading to very different organisational outcomes.

Some organisations choose what we call an "Economic Purpose" - they exist primarily to create financial returns for shareholders. Berkshire Hathaway under Warren Buffett exemplifies this approach with their clear focus on generating superior long-term returns for shareholders through disciplined capital allocation. Similarly, Goldman Sachs has traditionally positioned itself around maximising financial performance and shareholder value. This isn't wrong per se, and as discussed before it's important to capture the true organisational purpose not a PR statement, but it has specific implications for how you attract talent, make trade-offs, and sustain motivation during difficult periods.

Others choose a "Social Purpose" - they exist to solve important problems or serve important constituencies. Some refer to this type of Purpose as a "Massive Transformative Purpose" (MTP) - a highly aspirational purpose statement that transcends traditional mission statements. An MTP is characterised by being audaciously big, transformative in its potential to cause radical change to an industry or the world, and having a clear "why" that inspires action (Ismail, 2014, Exponential Organisations).

Take Patagonia, whose official purpose statement is "We're in business to save our home planet." This bold declaration has driven extraordinary business results: the company has achieved consistent

revenue growth with annual sales reaching \$1 billion, while maintaining an employee turnover rate of just 25% compared to the industry average of 43.8%. Their purpose-driven approach has attracted 900 applications per job opening and earned them placement on the Ethisphere Institute's "World's Most Ethical Companies" list for six consecutive years. Most remarkably, Patagonia's revenue has doubled since 2008, directly correlating with their increased commitment to environmental activism and transparency, demonstrating that purpose and profit can powerfully align.

Similarly, SpaceX's official mission "to make humanity multiplanetary" has revolutionised the space industry. Since its foundation in 2002, this ambitious purpose has enabled SpaceX to reduce launch costs by up to 90% through reusable rocket technology, capture over 60% of the global commercial launch market, and become the sole U.S. provider for crewed missions to the International Space Station. The company's MTP has attracted top-tier aerospace talent, secured billions in contracts from NASA and private customers, and positioned SpaceX as the most valuable private space company globally, valued at over \$180 billion. Their purpose-driven innovation has made space travel more accessible while advancing humanity's future as a multi-planetary species.

Still others choose what we might call a "Capability Purpose" - they exist to do something exceptionally well that creates value for others. Amazon perfectly exemplifies this approach with their official mission "to be Earth's Most Customer-Centric Company." From Jeff Bezos's first letter to shareholders in 1997, this capability-driven purpose has remained unwavering for over 25 years. Starting as an online bookshop in Bezos's garage, Amazon has methodically expanded into seemingly unrelated markets - cloud computing, artificial intelligence, groceries, entertainment, logistics, and even space exploration - all unified by their obsession with customer-centricity.

Core Values

The second element of the Winning Ambition framework, is your Core Values - the essential and enduring tenets of an organisation. These are a small set of timeless guiding principles that require no external justification; they have intrinsic value and importance to those inside the organisation. Companies tend to have only a few core values, usually between three and five. In fact, none of the visionary companies studied by Collins and Porras had more than five; most had only three or four.



Barrett's Cultural Transformation Tools - Core Values Framework (to be added later)

Here's what makes core values powerful in strategy: they create constraints that actually strengthen your position. Disney's core values of imagination and wholesomeness don't stem from market requirements but from Walt Disney's inner belief that these should be nurtured for their own sake.

When Johnson & Johnson prioritised customer safety over short-term profits during the Tylenol crisis, they were living their core values - and it ultimately strengthened their market position.

Example: Johnson & Johnson's Core Values under pressure



Johnson & Johnson's Core Values are embodied in their **Credo**, written by R.W. Johnson Jr in 1943. It is a hierarchy of responsibilities: 1) to patients, doctors, nurses, mothers, fathers and all who use their products; 2) to employees; 3) to communities where they live and work; and 4) to stockholders.

The Tylenol Crisis (1982)

- The Problem: 7 deaths from cyanide-laced Tylenol capsules in Chicago
- The Stakes: Tylenol = 17% of company profits, most valuable product
- The Pressure: Advisors recommended limited response to minimize damage

The Values-Driven Response

- Nationwide recall of 31M bottles (\$100M+ cost)
- Ceased all advertising
- Free product exchanges
- CEO appeared on national TV to address crisis personally
- Developed tamper-resistant packaging

The Strategic Outcome

- Trust: Built enormous consumer/provider goodwill
- Recovery: Market share exceeded pre-crisis levels within 12 months
- Leadership: Set industry standard for crisis management
- Strength: Brand became more trusted than before crisis

It's remarkably common to find still embedded deeply in the culture of very large and successful organisations the very personal values of the founder, sometimes decades after their passing. Consider Ferrero, the multi-billion dollar chocolate company now in its third generation under Giovanni Ferrero. Pietro Ferrero, the founder known affectionately as "the scientist" for his love of experimentation, established values that persist today: loyalty and trust, respect and responsibility, integrity and moderation, and passion for quality and research. The company maintains its founder's motto "Work Create Donate" through the Ferrero Foundation established in 1983, still provides free bus services for rural workers as Pietro did in 1946, and continues the community-focused approach that characterised the founder's vision. Their corporate culture remains "based on solid family values" that have shaped every major decision for nearly 80 years.

Similarly, Ferrari continues to embody Enzo Ferrari's relentless pursuit of excellence decades after his death in 1988. Known as "il Commendatore" (the Commander), Enzo's core values centred on uncompromising quality, continuous innovation, and what he called "a great mania" for racing. His famous declaration that "I should like to put something new into my cars every morning" still drives Ferrari's innovation culture today. His autocratic demand for perfection, his belief that "psychological pressure would produce better results," and his philosophy that entertainment was a distraction from duty continue to shape Ferrari's organisational culture. The prancing horse emblem, adopted from WWI pilot Francesco Baracca at Enzo's suggestion, remains the symbol of these enduring values that distinguish Ferrari's approach to both racing and luxury automotive manufacturing.

The Authenticity Test: To identify authentic core values, ask this crucial question about each proposed value: "If the circumstances changed and *penalised* us for holding this core value, would we

still keep it?" If you can't honestly answer yes, then the value is not core and should be dropped. As Ralph Larsen, former CEO of Johnson & Johnson, said: "The core values embodied in our credo might be a competitive advantage, but that is not why we have them. We have them because they define for us what we stand for, and we would hold them even if they became a competitive disadvantage in certain situations."

Here's what many organisations get wrong: they try to value everything, which means they actually value nothing. Effective organisations make hard choices about which values are truly core - usually no more than three to five - and then they live with the constraints those values create.

The strategic choice here is not what values sound good in a brochure, but what values you're actually willing to sacrifice short-term opportunities to maintain.

Netflix exemplifies this with their core values of "freedom and responsibility." They eliminated traditional vacation policies, expense approvals, and performance reviews, trusting employees to act responsibly. This created a high-performance culture but also means they're willing to quickly part ways with employees who don't embody these values, even if they're competent in their roles.

This approach mirrors the legendary leadership philosophy of Jack Welch, former CEO of General Electric, who developed what became known as the Performance-Values Matrix during his tenure from 1981-2001. Under his leadership, GE's market value increased from *14billion* to 410 billion - a 30-fold increase that made him one of the most successful CEOs in history. Welch's matrix evaluated employees along two independent dimensions: performance (results achieved) and values (alignment with company culture and principles).

The matrix created four categories of employees, but Welch's most controversial and insightful policy concerned high performers with low values - what he called the "most difficult" decisions. While most leaders would give second chances to high-performing employees who violated company values, Welch took the opposite approach: he would give second chances to low-performing employees who strongly embodied company values, but would terminate high performers who consistently failed to live the organisation's values, even if they delivered exceptional results. His reasoning was that "people with values challenges are usually hard-wired that way, and the destruction they sow on the group far outweighs the benefit of their individual performance."

This counter intuitive approach was validated by research from Bradley University, which studied 125 managers and found that performance and values are completely independent constructs that must be evaluated separately. The study concluded that organisations using Welch's Performance-Values Matrix significantly outperformed those using traditional values-based management approaches, demonstrating that values alignment and performance must be measured and managed as distinct but

equally important dimensions of organisational success (Buchko & Buchko, 2012, Journal of Business Leadership).

In conclusion, the core ideology - the combination of purpose and values - serves as one of the most powerful delegation tools available to any organisation. When an organisation achieves strong and deep alignment around its purpose and values, managers can trust their people to make decisions and behave according to these guiding principles without constant oversight or micromanagement. Employees become self-directed because they understand not just what to do, but why they're doing it and how they should approach their work. This creates the foundation for what truly empowered and autonomous organisations look like - where decision-making can be distributed throughout the organisation because everyone is operating from the same fundamental beliefs and aspirations. A strong core ideology is, therefore, not just inspirational rhetoric - it's a prerequisite for building the kind of high-trust, high-autonomy culture that enables organisations to scale effectively while maintaining coherence and alignment.

Vision

The third element is your Vision - what we call your "envisioned future." To craft a great vision, consider two distinct but interconnected parts: a Big, Hairy, Audacious Goal (BHAG) and a vivid description of what achieving it will look like. If you can craft a vision statement which has both elements, you are on the right track!

Big, Hairy, Audacious Goals (BHAGs) are ambitious plans that energise the entire organisation and typically require 10 to 30 years to complete. A true BHAG is short, clear and compelling, serves as a unifying focal point, and acts as a catalyst for team spirit. It should have perhaps only a 50% to 70% probability of success, but the organisation must believe it can reach the goal anyway. There are four broad categories of BHAGs:

- **Target BHAGs:** "Become a \$125 billion company by 2000" (Wal-Mart, 1990)
- **Common-enemy BHAGs:** "Crush Adidas" (Nike, 1960s)
- **Role-model BHAGs:** "Become the Nike of the cycling industry" (Giro Sport Design)
- **Internal-transformation BHAGs:** "Become number one or two in every market we serve" (General Electric)

Vivid Description. It is often useful to accompany the BHAG with a more vivid narrative, which translates the vision from words into images and pictures - creating memorable statements which people can carry in their heads and hearts.

Examples of Vision



“ We will land a man on the moon and return him safely to the earth by the end of this decade. ”

U.S. President John F. Kennedy (1961)

SONY

“ We will create products that become pervasive around the world.... We will be the first Japanese company to go into the U.S. market and distribute directly.... We will succeed at innovations that U.S. companies have failed at—such as the transistor radio.... Fifty years from now, our brand name will be as well-known as any in the world... and will signify innovation and quality that rival the most innovative companies anywhere.... ”

“Made in Japan” will mean something fine, not something shoddy. ”

Sony, 1950s

Consider Sony in the 1950s - a small, cash-strapped startup founded in a bombed-out department store in post-war Tokyo, employing just 20 people and making rice cookers and heating pads. Japan in 1950 was a nation still reeling from devastating defeat, with "Made in Japan" synonymous worldwide with cheap, shoddy imitations. American occupation forces controlled the country, and Japanese products were banned from many international markets. Into this context of national humiliation, Sony proclaimed the audacious BHAG "to become the company most known for changing the worldwide poor-quality image of Japanese products."

But what made this vision truly powerful was how they painted the picture: "We will create products that become pervasive around the world. We will be the first Japanese company to go into the U.S. market and distribute directly. We will succeed with innovations that U.S. companies have failed at--- such as the transistor radio.... Fifty years from now, our brand name will be as well known as any in the world... and will signify innovation and quality that rival the most innovative companies anywhere. 'Made in Japan' will mean something fine, not something shoddy."

This vivid description accomplished something remarkable: it transformed national shame into fierce pride, channelled defeat into determination, and positioned America - the occupying power that had humbled Japan - as the ultimate target to surpass. The emotional resonance was profound: employees weren't just building radios, they were restoring Japan's honour. They weren't just competing with American companies, they were proving Japanese ingenuity could triumph over those who had once defeated them. This David-versus-Goliath narrative rallied not just minds but hearts, creating an almost patriotic fervour around the company's mission that sustained Sony through decades of seemingly impossible challenges.

You can choose to articulate a narrow, industry-specific vision that provides very clear direction through a single BHAG, but might limit future options. Or you can choose a broader, more aspirational

vision that allows flexibility but might provide less day-to-day guidance. This is a choice that can change over time.

A BHAG without vivid description is just another goal. You must translate vision from words into pictures that people can carry in their heads. This means painting a picture with your words, creating an image that makes the 10-30 year BHAG tangible in people's minds.

Henry Ford didn't just say "democratise the automobile." He brought it to life: "I will build a motor car for the great multitude... It will be so low in price that no man making a good salary will be unable to own one and enjoy with his family the blessing of hours of pleasure in God's great open spaces... When I'm through, everybody will be able to afford one, and everyone will have one. The horse will have disappeared from our highways."

In the 1930s, when Merck set the BHAG to transform from a chemical manufacturer into a pre-eminent drug company, George Merck painted this vivid picture: "We believe that research work carried on with patience and persistence will bring to industry and commerce new life... Let your light so shine - that those who seek the Truth, that those who toil that this world may be a better place to live in... shall take new courage and feel their hands supported."

Passion, emotion, and conviction are essential parts of vivid description. Some managers are uncomfortable expressing emotion about their dreams, but that's exactly what motivates others to give their best effort toward seemingly impossible goals.

Level of Ambition

The fourth and final element of the Winning Ambition framework is your **Level of Ambition** - a balanced set of 10-15 metrics that translate your Vision and Purpose into measurable numbers across multiple dimensions of organisational performance. This is crucial because it prevents the common trap of having inspiring rhetoric that doesn't connect to real performance expectations.

The Balanced Scorecard Framework provides the most effective structure for defining your Level of Ambition. Developed by Kaplan and Norton, this framework organises your metrics across four interconnected perspectives that capture the full complexity of organisational performance:



1. Financial Perspective: What will our shareholders and investors receive?

- Revenue growth rates
- Profitability measures
- Return on investment
- Cost efficiency ratios

2. Customer Perspective: What will our customers say about us?

- Customer satisfaction scores
- Market share growth
- Customer retention rates
- Net Promoter Scores

3. Internal Process Perspective: What must we excel at operationally?

- Quality metrics
- Process efficiency measures
- Innovation rates
- Operational excellence indicators

4. Learning & Growth Perspective: How will we sustain our ability to change and improve?

- Employee engagement scores

- Skills development metrics
- Technology advancement measures
- Knowledge management indicators

The Cause-and-Effect Logic: These four perspectives are not independent silos but form a connected chain of causality. Investments in learning and growth (developing capabilities, skills, and systems) drive improvements in internal processes (quality, efficiency, innovation). Superior internal processes lead to better customer outcomes (satisfaction, loyalty, market position). And better customer outcomes ultimately generate superior financial results (revenue, profitability, returns).

Your level of ambition should make clear what "winning" means in quantifiable terms across all four perspectives. You cannot manage a complex organisation using single measures alone - it's like trying to fly an aeroplane with only one instrument. But you must choose how to balance financial results with customer outcomes, short-term performance with long-term capability building, and individual achievement with collective success.

Think of your Level of Ambition as the GPS coordinates for a breathtakingly beautiful, remote tropical island that you're determined to reach - even though you know the journey will be difficult and perilous. You may have stunning photographs of this paradise (your Vision statement) that inspire and motivate everyone on your team. The images show crystal-clear turquoise waters, pristine white beaches, and swaying palm trees that capture everyone's imagination and fuel their desire to get there. But pictures alone, no matter how compelling, won't actually get you to your destination.

To ensure you'll successfully navigate through storms, around dangerous reefs, and across vast stretches of open ocean, you must transform those inspiring images into a precise set of GPS coordinates - exact latitude and longitude numbers that your navigation systems can lock onto and guide you toward, no matter how challenging the conditions become. Your Level of Ambition serves exactly this function: it converts the inspiring picture of your vision into specific, measurable coordinates that everyone in your organisation can navigate toward.

Aligning your leadership team on these key metrics and their specific target values represents the first major step toward reaching your Winning Ambition. Just as a ship's crew must all be reading from the same navigational instruments and heading toward the same coordinates, your entire organisation needs to be aligned on what success looks like in concrete, measurable terms. Without this precision, you'll have passionate people rowing in different directions, each believing they're heading toward the same beautiful destination but actually steering toward entirely different points on the horizon.

But remember - these metrics must be genuinely ambitious, not just incremental improvements. They should stretch your organisation's performance expectations and require breakthrough thinking to

achieve. If your targets can be reached through business as usual, they're not ambitious enough to constitute a true Winning Ambition.

How high do you set your sights? This choice must balance several considerations: ambitious enough to inspire breakthrough performance, realistic enough to maintain organisational confidence, specific enough to guide decisions, and flexible enough to accommodate changing circumstances.

Some organisations choose what we call "Stretch Ambitions" - goals that require fundamentally new capabilities or approaches. Others choose "Extension Ambitions" - goals that push current capabilities to their limits. Still others choose "Transformation Ambitions" - goals that require becoming a fundamentally different kind of organisation.

Each approach has different implications for risk, resource requirements, timeline, and organisational culture. The choice depends on your current competitive position, available resources, market dynamics, and organisational appetite for change.

Starbucks under Howard Schultz chose a "Transformation Ambition" when they set out to become "the third place between work and home" rather than just selling coffee. This required building entirely new capabilities in real estate, store design, employee culture, and customer experience. The ambition was so audacious it required fundamentally changing what it meant to be a coffee company.

Why the Winning Ambition Matters

Posteitaliane

Example:

The Context

Poste Italiane is the Italian postal service provider, who a few years ago had:

- No trust from customers in domestic delivery
- 30 minutes + waiting times in most post offices
- Productivity amongst the lowest in the world

They Established Vision, Purpose and Level of Ambition

VISION		LEVEL OF AMBITION		
The Vision	Dimension	Measure of Success	From	To
"Deliver a service to be proud of..."	Customer	Time to serve a customer during peak time	30 Minutes	10 Minutes

The entire organisation aligned towards a common goal

- ✓ **Postmen** realised that by delivering packages correctly fewer people would go to the post office
- ✓ The **office workers** could increase the speed of service by being properly trained and using adequate technology
- ✓ **Executives** evaluated any investment by looking at how much it would reduce queues at post offices
- ✓ **Suppliers and stakeholders** were encouraged and motivated to suggest improvements

The Results

- After 24 months the average queuing time decreased to less than five minutes, exceeding its targets
- Significantly increased profitability

But here's why this matters so much for practical strategy execution: Organisations with clear, compelling winning ambitions consistently outperform those with vague or purely financial aspirations. They attract better talent, make faster decisions, allocate resources more effectively, and maintain

strategic focus even when facing short-term pressures. The stretch element is particularly crucial - when organisations set genuinely ambitious goals, they unlock creativity, innovation, and performance levels that would never emerge from modest, easily achievable targets. This stretch forces them to think fundamentally differently about how they operate and compete.



Think about Amazon's winning ambition. Their purpose is to be "Earth's Most Customer-Centric Company." Their core values include customer obsession, ownership, and long-term thinking. Their vision is to be the place where customers can find and discover anything they might want to buy online. And their level of ambition is measured not just by revenue growth, but by customer satisfaction scores, delivery speed, product selection, and innovation metrics.

Notice how every major strategic decision Amazon makes - from their investment in AWS to their acquisition of Whole Foods to their development of Alexa - can be evaluated against these winning ambition criteria. Does it serve customers better? Does it align with their values? Does it move them toward their envisioned future? Does it contribute to their ambitious performance targets?

This is the power of a well-crafted Winning Ambition: it doesn't just inspire people - it provides a practical framework for making strategic choices under uncertainty.

Section 2: Diagnostic Questions

Developing a compelling Winning Ambition requires understanding what people throughout your organisation currently believe, think, and feel about your purpose, values, vision, and level of ambition.

The diagnostic phase serves the crucial purpose of capturing these individual perspectives and beliefs, so that an aggregated picture can be formed to inform how to frame and structure your Winning Ambition effectively.

The power of this approach lies in recognising that while leadership teams may have their own perspectives on the organisation's direction and identity, the most successful Winning Ambitions emerge from understanding the authentic beliefs, aspirations, and concerns that exist throughout the organisation. Only by systematically gathering these insights can you craft a Winning Ambition that resonates deeply and drives genuine alignment.

Implementation Approaches:

For Small Executive Groups (typically 5-15 senior leaders): Conduct in-depth 1-to-1 interviews lasting 30-60 minutes each. This approach allows for nuanced exploration of complex topics, follow-up questions that dig deeper into underlying assumptions, and the opportunity to surface sensitive issues that might not emerge in group settings.

For Larger Organisational Sections (departments, business units, or entire organisations): Deploy large-scale surveys that can efficiently capture input from hundreds or thousands of employees. These surveys should balance quantitative ratings (to enable statistical analysis and benchmarking) with open-ended qualitative questions (to capture rich insights and unexpected perspectives).

The five diagnostic questions that follow are designed to reveal important insights about where you stand today, what gaps exist between current reality and aspirational goals, and what might need to change to achieve your Winning Ambition.

Question 1: What is our Purpose?

This fundamental question goes beyond asking whether you have a mission statement. It's about understanding whether your organisation has a clear, compelling reason for existence that actually guides decision-making and inspires action.

The Five Whys Technique: Start with "We make X products" or "We deliver X services" and ask "Why is that important?" five times. After a few whys, you'll get to your fundamental purpose.

Sub-questions to consider:

- Can every employee articulate why your organisation exists in terms that go beyond making money?
- Does your purpose inspire people at all levels, not just executives?
- Would this purpose motivate someone to continue working here even if they had enough money to retire?
- Does your purpose reflect people's idealistic motivations for doing the company's work?

- Could your purpose guide the organisation for at least 100 years, regardless of changes in products, markets, or technologies?
- Does your purpose capture the soul of the organisation, not just describe current operations?

Question 2: What are our Values, beliefs and culture?

This question examines whether your organisation has identified the 3-5 principles that will never be compromised and whether these principles actually serve as a powerful delegation tool that enables autonomous decision-making throughout the organisation.

Core Values Discovery Questions (work from individual to organisation):

- What core values do you personally bring to your work that are so fundamental you would hold them regardless of whether they were rewarded? It is often useful to present to the interviewees/survey respondents comprehensive lists of values (both positive and negative) and asking them to choose a small set (e.g. maximum 10) which they believe represent how people make decisions and act in the organisation.
- What would you tell your children are the core values you hold at work and hope they will hold as working adults?
- If you awoke tomorrow with enough money to retire, would you continue to live those core values?
- Can you envision them being as valid 100 years from now as they are today?
- **The Critical Test:** Would you want to hold those core values even if at some point they became a competitive disadvantage?
- If you started a new organisation in a different industry, what core values would you build in regardless of that industry?

Organisational Validation Questions:

- Do your hiring, promotion, and performance evaluation processes explicitly reinforce these values?
- Can you identify specific business opportunities you've declined because they conflicted with your values?
- When conflicts arise between values and financial pressures, which consistently wins?

Delegation and Autonomy Questions:

- Can employees make decisions independently using your core values as guidance, without requiring constant oversight?
- Do your values provide clear enough direction that people know how to behave when managers aren't present?
- Would you trust someone who deeply understands your values to make important decisions even if they're not senior in the hierarchy?
- Do your values help people resolve conflicts between competing priorities without escalating every

decision to management?

- **The Empowerment Test:** If you had to manage a distributed team across multiple time zones with minimal direct supervision, would your core values provide sufficient guidance for consistent decision-making?

Question 3: What is our Vision?

This question assesses whether your organisation has a Big, Hairy, Audacious Goal (BHAG) plus vivid description that provides direction for resource allocation and strategic choices.

BHAG Assessment Questions:

- Do you have a 10-30 year goal that is clear and compelling enough to serve as a unifying focal point?
- Is your goal audacious enough that it has perhaps only a 50-70% probability of success, yet the organisation believes it can achieve it?
- Does your BHAG fall into one of these categories: Target (quantitative/qualitative), Common-enemy (David vs. Goliath), Role-model (emulate another organisation), or Internal-transformation (change what you are)?
- Does your goal require extraordinary effort and perhaps a little luck?
- Would your goal continue to motivate the organisation even if the leaders who set it disappeared?

Vivid Description Questions:

- Can you paint a vibrant, engaging picture of what it will be like to achieve your BHAG?
- If someone writes a business magazine article about your company in 20 years, what would it say?
- What would success look, feel, and sound like to employees, customers, and competitors?
- Does your description translate the vision from words into pictures people can carry in their heads?

Question 4: What is our Level of Ambition?

This question examines whether you've translated your purpose, values, and vision into specific, measurable performance expectations that serve as the "GPS coordinates" for your organisational destination. It explores whether you have the precise metrics needed to navigate toward your Winning Ambition across all four perspectives of the Balanced Scorecard framework.

Financial Perspective Questions:

- What specific financial returns will we deliver to our shareholders and investors when we achieve our vision?
- What will our revenue growth, profitability, and return on investment targets look like?

Customer Perspective Questions:

- What will our customers say about us when we've achieved our vision? How will they describe their experience?
- What customer satisfaction, retention, and market share metrics will demonstrate our success?

Internal Process Perspective Questions:

- What must we be exceptionally good at operationally to achieve our vision?
- What quality, efficiency, and innovation metrics will indicate we're excelling in our core processes?

Learning & Growth Perspective Questions:

- How will we sustain our ability to change and improve as we work toward our vision?
- What employee engagement, capability development, and knowledge management metrics will ensure our continued evolution?

Integration and Ambition Level Questions:

- Are our performance targets ambitious enough to require breakthrough thinking and innovation, or can they be achieved through incremental improvements?
- Can you trace the cause-and-effect logic: how investments in learning and growth drive process improvements, which lead to better customer outcomes, which generate superior financial results?
- Do we have leading indicators that help predict whether we'll achieve our long-term ambitions, or do we only measure lagging results?
- How do our ambition levels compare to the best performers in our industry, and do they reflect our strategic positioning choices?

Question 5: What do we need to change?

This final question helps identify gaps between your current reality and the Winning Ambition framework we've outlined, and it points toward specific areas for improvement.

Sub-questions to consider:

- Where are the biggest gaps between your stated aspirations and your actual organisational capabilities or behaviours?
- What aspects of your current culture, systems, or processes actively work against achieving your Winning Ambition?
- Which elements of your Winning Ambition framework are unclear, contradictory, or insufficiently developed to guide strategic choices?
- What would need to change in your leadership behaviours, resource allocation, or performance management to better support your ambitions?
- How do your employees, customers, and other stakeholders perceive your purpose, values, and ambitions, and where do these perceptions differ from your intentions?

These diagnostic questions are designed to be used iteratively. As you work through them, you'll likely discover that answering one question raises new questions about others. This is normal and valuable - it indicates that you're developing a more sophisticated understanding of how the elements of Winning Ambition interconnect.

The goal isn't to have perfect answers to every question, but to develop increasing clarity about where you stand, where you want to go, and what needs to change to get there.